

VIFM COMPETENCY-BASED INTERVIEW (CBI)

Interview Guide

Senior Finance Manager · Financial services (illustrative) · 120 minutes · 6 competencies

THIS INTERVIEW

Candidate	
Date and time	
Lead interviewer	
Second interviewer	
Location / link	
Guide version	SFM-01 (sample)

COMPETENCIES IN THIS GUIDE

COMPETENCY	DOMAIN	TARGET
Critical Analysis & Judgement	Thinking	4.0
Strategic & Commercial Insight	Thinking	3.5
Delivery & Accountability	Results	4.0
Influence & Agreement	People	3.5
Coaching & Talent Growth	People	3.5
Resilience & Composure	Self	3.5

Target is the level the role requires on the 1 to 5 scale, taken from the role profile. High-priority competencies are shown in navy.

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

This guide is generated from the VIFM Competency Framework for one role. It contains, for each competency, the definition, the behavioural indicators used to classify evidence, three standard questions with probes, space for notes, and the anchored rating scale. Every candidate for this role is asked the same questions in the same order. Only the probes vary with the answers. The guide is a confidential assessment instrument and is not shared with candidates.

INTERVIEW PLAN (120 MINUTES)

TIME	SEGMENT	PURPOSE
0 to 10	Opening	Welcome, purpose, the competencies covered, note-taking and recording explained, consent confirmed, questions about the process.
10 to 20	Career overview	Recent roles and responsibilities in brief. Settles the candidate and surfaces examples to return to. Not rated.
20 to 110	Six competencies	About fifteen minutes each in the order of this guide. Ask, probe for the candidate's own actions, record, summarise, move on.
110 to 120	Close	Anything to add, the candidate's questions, next steps and timing. Thank the candidate.

How to use this guide

1. PREPARE

- ✓ Read the role profile and this guide in full. Know the indicators for each competency before the day.
- ✓ Review the CV and any prior assessment data. Note areas to probe, but ask the standard questions first.
- ✓ Agree with the second interviewer who leads and who records for each competency.
- ✓ Check the room or the link, water, timing, and that the candidate's joining information was sent.

2. CONDUCT

- ✓ Open with the purpose, the competencies covered and how notes are taken. Put the candidate at ease.
- ✓ Ask each question as written. Use the probes to get to the candidate's own actions and the result.
- ✓ Redirect answers in the hypothetical or the plural to a specific, personal example.
- ✓ Summarise what you heard before moving on. Do not evaluate, agree or disagree in the room.
- ✓ Close with the candidate's questions, next steps and thanks.

3. ASSESS

- ✓ Write up notes the same day, before rating.
- ✓ Classify each piece of evidence against one competency's positive or negative indicators.
- ✓ Rate each competency against its anchors. The rating is the anchor the evidence best fits.
- ✓ No evidence means NE, never a 1. Record why.
- ✓ Calibrate with the second interviewer with the notes on the table, then complete the summary sheet.

STAR-L: THE SHAPE OF EVERY ANSWER

- S Situation** What was the context? When, where, who was involved?
- T Task** What was the candidate responsible for? What had to be achieved?
- A Action** What did the candidate, personally, do? Spend most of the time here.
- R Result** What happened? How do they know? What did it deliver or cost?
- L Learning** What would they do differently? What did they carry into the next situation?

NOTE-TAKING RULES

- ✓ Record what the candidate said and did, in their words where possible. Facts, not adjectives.
- ✓ Mark each note with the competency it belongs to. One piece of evidence can support only one competency.
- ✓ Note the absence of evidence as well: a question answered in generalities, or an example that stayed at "we".
- ✓ Keep notes legible and job-related. They form part of the assessment record and may be reviewed.

COMMON RATING ERRORS TO AVOID

Halo from one strong answer; recency from the last competency; similarity to the interviewer; rating fluency rather than behaviour; and rating a hypothetical answer as if it had happened.

THE RATING SCALE

5

Role model

Consistently exceeds the role requirement; several strong, specific examples with clear personal ownership.

4

Above requirement

Above requirement in most situations; clear positive evidence with few gaps.

3

Meets requirement

Adequate; meets the role requirement, evidence may be uneven across the indicators.

2

Development needed

Below requirement; limited or mixed evidence, some negative indicators present.

1

Significant gap

Little or no positive evidence; negative indicators dominate the examples given.

NE

No evidence

The interview produced no usable evidence for this competency. Never rated as a 1.

Every competency page carries its own anchors for each point. Rate against those anchors, not against these general labels. A 3 means the role requirement is met.

Critical Analysis & Judgement

4.0

DEFINITION

Breaks ambiguous, data-heavy problems into their parts, tests assumptions, and weighs competing explanations before reaching a view. Turns that reasoning into timely, balanced decisions, even when information is incomplete, weighing risk, stakeholders and second-order consequences. Stands behind decisions with reasoning that holds up to scrutiny.

Why it matters in this role. A senior finance manager is the organisation's check on the numbers and the story behind them. Weak judgement here reaches the board.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- ✓ Judges the relevance and importance of different pieces of information accurately
- ✓ Identifies underlying relationships, causes and effects
- ✓ Identifies potential weaknesses in proposals or plans
- ✓ Makes well-informed decisions after considering the relevant information
- ✓ Decides on a course of action without unnecessary delay
- ✓ Takes accountability for decisions made

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- ✗ Draws conclusions without sufficient evidence
- ✗ Fails to identify inconsistencies in data or arguments
- ✗ Avoids making decisions or defers unnecessarily
- ✗ Makes decisions without considering relevant information or alternatives

1. Tell me about a time the numbers you were given did not add up, and you had to get to the bottom of it.

- What first made you doubt the figures?
- How did you separate the cause from the symptoms?
- What did you decide, and what happened as a result?

Notes

2. Describe a significant decision you had to make with incomplete information.

- What did you know, and what did you have to assume?
- How did you weigh the risks and the people affected?
- Looking back, what would you do differently?

Notes

3. Give me an example of a proposal or business case you challenged because you saw a weakness others had missed.

- What was the weakness and how did you find it?
- How did the people behind the proposal respond?
- What was the outcome for the organisation?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- | | |
|---|---|
| 5 | Dissects highly ambiguous, data-heavy problems with precision, probes underlying causes, and surfaces weaknesses others miss. Makes difficult, well-justified decisions confidently despite incomplete information, articulates trade-offs clearly, and influences others' thinking through the quality and transparency of reasoning demonstrated. |
| 4 | Quickly distinguishes critical from peripheral information, uncovers hidden problems, and weighs multiple competing explanations before deciding. Makes sound decisions under pressure, anticipates second-order consequences, and defends choices with well-structured reasoning that withstands scrutiny. |
| 3 | Systematically examines the main elements of the problem, identifies obvious inconsistencies, and tests key assumptions. Reaches a timely, balanced decision that considers the primary risks and stakeholder needs, and explains the rationale clearly when challenged. |
| 2 | Reviews some information but misses key inconsistencies or fails to distinguish relevant from irrelevant data. Reaches a decision eventually but overlooks important risks, stakeholder concerns, or alternative options in the reasoning presented. |
| 1 | Jumps to conclusions without examining available data or testing assumptions. Defers decisions repeatedly or avoids taking a position when asked to recommend a course of action, even when information is sufficient. |

Strategic & Commercial Insight

3.5

DEFINITION

Reads the competitive, economic and regulatory landscape and anticipates how markets and client needs will shift. Converts that insight into a clear, prioritised direction framed around long-term value, and links day-to-day work to the commercial outcomes it should produce. Sets direction others can understand, align to and act on.

Why it matters in this role. The role turns financial data into direction for the business, not only a record of it.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- ✓ Shows an overall view of the business and its links to the external environment
- ✓ Shows awareness of the revenue, cost and risk factors that drive performance
- ✓ Anticipates future trends and opportunities before they arrive
- ✓ Demonstrates long-term thinking when setting goals
- ✓ Prioritises financial considerations when making decisions
- ✓ Identifies new and promising business opportunities

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- ✗ Focuses only on short-term solutions without considering strategic implications
- ✗ Overlooks market trends or competitive threats
- ✗ Fails to consider the broader impact of decisions on other departments
- ✗ Makes decisions without considering financial impact

1. Tell me about a time you used financial analysis to change a commercial or strategic decision in your organisation.

- What did the analysis show that others had not seen?
- How did you connect it to the longer-term direction?
- What changed as a result, and how did you measure it?

Notes

2. Describe a time you saw a market, economic or regulatory shift coming and acted on it before it hit.

- What signals did you pick up, and where from?
- What did you do, and who did you need to convince?
- How did it play out?

Notes

3. Give me an example of a trade-off between short-term results and long-term value that you had to make.

- What were the options and their financial consequences?
- How did you reach your view?
- What was the result over the following year?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- 5 Synthesises complex competitive, economic and regulatory intelligence to paint a compelling future scenario that shifts others' thinking. Translates this vision into prioritised strategic initiatives with explicit commercial logic that mobilises teams and drives alignment across organisational boundaries.
- 4 Proactively identifies emerging market opportunities or regulatory shifts and explains how these create specific business value. Frames recommendations around long-term positioning while clearly linking daily activities to measurable commercial outcomes that resonate with stakeholders.
- 3 Articulates how current market trends affect the business and connects proposed actions to revenue or cost drivers. Explains priorities with clear rationale that balances immediate needs with longer-term commercial objectives in an understandable way.
- 2 References market conditions when prompted but offers limited analysis of competitive threats or opportunities. Proposes solutions focused primarily on short-term fixes with minimal consideration of cost implications or strategic alignment.
- 1 Focuses exclusively on immediate tasks without acknowledging broader market context or competitive factors. Makes recommendations that ignore financial implications or impact on other business areas, demonstrating no awareness of long-term consequences.

Delivery & Accountability

4.0

DEFINITION

Takes personal responsibility for measurable results and follows through from commitment to completion, sustaining standards when conditions are difficult. Holds self and others to what was promised, owns mistakes openly and fixes them rather than shifting blame. Builds a track record of reliability the organisation can plan around.

Why it matters in this role. Close, reporting and audit deadlines do not move. The organisation plans around this person's reliability.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- Follows through on promises and commitments
- Works well under pressure and meets tight deadlines
- Attends to multiple tasks without losing focus
- Accepts appropriate responsibility when things go wrong
- Maintains standards when carrying out demanding tasks
- Adheres to the organisation's regulations and policies

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- Fails to meet commitments or deadlines
- Blames others when things go wrong
- Loses focus when managing multiple priorities
- Fails to follow through on commitments

1. Tell me about the most demanding deadline you have delivered against, where the quality could not slip.

- What made it demanding?
- What did you personally do to protect both the date and the standard?
- What was the result?

Notes

2. Describe a time you or your team got something wrong that mattered, and what you did about it.

- How did you find out, and how quickly did you own it?
- What did you say to the people affected?
- What did you put in place so it would not recur?

Notes

3. Give me an example of a commitment you could not keep. What happened?

- When did you realise, and who did you tell?
- What did you offer instead?
- What did you learn about how you commit?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- Sets and meets demanding deadlines without letting quality slip, flags risks to delivery before they land, owns the team's shortfalls as well as their own, and puts in place a fix that stops the problem recurring.
- Proactively updates others on progress, meets demanding deadlines while maintaining quality standards, openly admits errors and immediately proposes corrective actions that address root causes effectively.
- Delivers agreed tasks on time consistently, acknowledges own role when discussing setbacks without deflecting blame, and maintains steady focus across concurrent responsibilities while adhering to established procedures.
- Completes some tasks but misses agreed timelines on others, offers explanations that minimise personal responsibility, and loses track of commitments when handling multiple priorities simultaneously.
- Misses deadlines without prior notice, blames external factors or colleagues when tasks are incomplete, and fails to follow through on multiple commitments made during discussions.

Influence & Agreement

3.5

DEFINITION

Builds well-reasoned, audience-aware cases that win genuine commitment, and addresses concerns rather than overriding them. Surfaces and resolves disagreement directly and calmly, keeping the focus on the issue. Reaches durable agreements through preparation and fair trade-offs, holding firm on what matters while staying flexible on how.

Why it matters in this role. Budgets, controls and cost decisions are won through business heads, auditors and the board, not imposed.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- ✓ Develops logical arguments from facts and data
- ✓ Positions arguments with the viewpoints and concerns of others in mind
- ✓ Remains committed to a position when faced with opposition where it matters
- ✓ Manages conflict with a minimum of noise
- ✓ Negotiates to gain agreement and reach mutually beneficial outcomes
- ✓ Navigates political situations sensitively and diplomatically

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- ✗ Relies on position or authority rather than evidence to persuade
- ✗ Avoids conflict situations rather than addressing them
- ✗ Concedes too easily without pursuing the best outcome
- ✗ Takes an inflexible position that prevents agreement

1. Tell me about a time you had to win support for a financial decision that a senior stakeholder opposed.

- How did you prepare, and what did you learn about their concerns?
- What did you hold firm on, and where did you flex?
- What agreement did you reach, and did it hold?

Notes

2. Describe a disagreement between you and a business unit over budget, cost or control, and how you resolved it.

- How did you keep it on the issue rather than the people?
- What trade-off made the agreement possible?
- How was the relationship afterwards?

Notes

3. Give me an example of a time you had to say no to a request from someone senior to you.

- How did you make the case?
- How did they react, and what did you do next?
- What was the outcome?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- 5 Presents persuasive cases that connect facts to emotional viewpoints, visibly shifting others' thinking and earning credibility. Transforms conflicts into productive dialogue through skilled questioning and reframing. Negotiates durable agreements that optimise outcomes for all parties and build lasting consensus.
- 4 Delivers compelling, evidence-based arguments that demonstrate clear understanding of others' perspectives and concerns. Navigates disagreements diplomatically, surfacing underlying issues and finding creative solutions. Achieves outcomes that gain genuine commitment while holding firm on critical points.
- 3 Builds logical cases using relevant facts and data tailored to the audience. Addresses objections calmly and directly, keeping discussions focused on issues rather than personalities. Reaches fair agreements through balanced trade-offs that meet core objectives.
- 2 Offers arguments with some supporting facts but struggles to adapt message to audience concerns. Addresses disagreements hesitantly or inconsistently. Reaches agreements but misses opportunities for better outcomes through premature compromise.
- 1 Presents weak or unsupported arguments that fail to persuade others. Avoids addressing objections directly, either conceding immediately or becoming defensive. Leaves disagreements unresolved or escalates minor issues unnecessarily.

Coaching & Talent Growth

3.5

DEFINITION

Actively develops others toward both their own potential and the organisation's future needs. Combines honest, specific feedback with stretching opportunities and the support to succeed in them, adapting to each person's readiness and aspirations. Builds capability and confidence that outlast any single task and strengthen the wider talent pipeline.

Why it matters in this role. The finance team's bench strength is this manager's responsibility, and the CFO's succession depends on it.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- ✓ Provides objective and timely feedback to others
- ✓ Identifies the strengths and limitations of others accurately
- ✓ Encourages others to consider and pursue development opportunities
- ✓ Clearly defines roles, responsibilities and objectives for others
- ✓ Monitors the performance of others and follows up
- ✓ Judges the future potential of others accurately

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- ✗ Does not provide feedback or development guidance
- ✗ Fails to recognise or nurture potential in team members
- ✗ Delegates for convenience rather than for growth
- ✗ Lets performance problems drift rather than addressing them

1. Tell me about someone you developed who went on to take a bigger role.

- What potential did you see, and how?
- What specifically did you do, and how did you adapt it to them?
- Where are they now, and what part did you play?

Notes

2. Describe a time you had to give difficult feedback to a team member about their performance.

- How did you prepare, and what did you actually say?
- How did they respond?
- What changed over the following months?

Notes

3. Give me an example of a stretch assignment you gave someone that carried a real risk of failure.

- Why that person and that task?
- How did you support them without taking it back?
- What was the result for them and for the work?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- 5 Gives candid, specific feedback the other person can act on, links it to a stretching opportunity that fits both their aspirations and the organisation's needs, and agrees concrete next steps and how progress will be checked.
- 4 Delivers timely, specific feedback tailored to individual readiness and actively encourages pursuit of stretching development opportunities. Accurately assesses potential and adapts support to build confidence and capability beyond immediate tasks.
- 3 Provides clear, objective feedback on performance and defines roles and responsibilities adequately. Identifies strengths and development areas, discusses relevant growth opportunities, and monitors progress in a structured manner.
- 2 Gives feedback occasionally but lacks specificity or timeliness. Recognises some development needs when prompted but provides limited guidance on how to address them or pursue growth opportunities.
- 1 Avoids giving feedback to others or offers only vague, unhelpful comments. Misses obvious development needs and shows no interest in discussing growth opportunities or future potential with team members.

Resilience & Composure

3.5

DEFINITION

Stays calm, clear and constructive under pressure, scrutiny and setbacks, keeping emotion in check so thinking stays sharp. Recovers quickly from disappointment and learns from it. Manages energy and the competing demands of work and life so performance holds up over time, not just in the moment.

Why it matters in this role. Year-end, audits, regulator queries and board scrutiny arrive together. Composure under that load sets the tone for the team.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- ✓ Remains calm and objective under pressure
- ✓ Retains focus and concentration when under pressure at work
- ✓ Keeps difficulties in perspective and displays optimism in negative situations
- ✓ Does not openly show frustration or dissatisfaction
- ✓ Manages energy and workload sustainably
- ✓ Models sustainable work practices for others

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- ⊖ Loses composure or focus under pressure
- ⊖ Shows visible frustration when things go wrong
- ⊖ Loses concentration or makes errors under pressure
- ⊖ Consistently overworks to the detriment of wellbeing, or expects the team to do the same

1. Tell me about the most pressured period you have worked through, when several demands landed at once.

- What was the pressure, and how did it show up in you?
- What did you do to keep your thinking clear and the team steady?
- What was the outcome, and what did it cost you?

Notes

2. Describe a setback at work that genuinely knocked you back.

- What happened, and how did you react in the first days?
- What helped you recover?
- What did you take from it?

Notes

3. Give me an example of being challenged hard in public, by a board member, auditor or regulator, for instance.

- What was said, and what did you feel?
- How did you respond in the moment?
- What happened afterwards?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

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NE

- 5 Remains clear-headed in the most pressured moments and helps others stay focused. Treats setbacks as information, adjusts quickly and keeps the group's confidence up without playing down the difficulty.
- 4 Stays composed under significant pressure, with sharp focus and constructive responses. Rebounds quickly from a setback, names what can be learned from it and reorganises the remaining work to recover lost ground.
- 3 Stays calm and focused as pressure rises, keeping emotions in check and thinking clearly. Recovers from a setback without dwelling on it and keeps performance steady to the end.
- 2 Maintains composure in routine situations but shows signs of stress when pressure increases. Occasionally displays frustration or loses concentration during challenges, though attempts to regain control and continues working through difficulties.
- 1 Becomes visibly flustered when challenged or when time runs short, loses focus and makes avoidable errors, and lets a setback early in the exercise affect the rest of the task.

Summary rating sheet

Complete after the write-up and the calibration discussion. Ratings must be traceable to the notes on the competency pages.

COMPETENCY	TARGET	LEAD	SECOND	AGREED	EVIDENCE
Critical Analysis & Judgement Thinking	4.0				Strong / Adequate / Thin
Strategic & Commercial Insight Thinking	3.5				Strong / Adequate / Thin
Delivery & Accountability Results	4.0				Strong / Adequate / Thin
Influence & Agreement People	3.5				Strong / Adequate / Thin
Coaching & Talent Growth People	3.5				Strong / Adequate / Thin
Resilience & Composure Self	3.5				Strong / Adequate / Thin

 HEADLINE STRENGTHS

 DEVELOPMENT AREAS

 DEVIATIONS FROM THE STANDARD SET, INTERRUPTIONS, OR ANYTHING THE PANEL SHOULD KNOW

 INTERVIEWER DECLARATION

We confirm that the standard questions in this guide were asked, that the ratings above are based on the recorded evidence, and that no information outside the interview and the agreed assessment data influenced them.

Lead interviewer

Second interviewer

Signature / date

Signature / date

This guide and the completed notes are part of the assessment record. They are retained in line with the client agreement and VIFM's retention schedule, and may be reviewed in the event of a query or appeal.